FIELD FORCE

Popularity in sports is **not the exclusive domain of male cricketers**; P.V. Sindhu continues her reign at the top

By **SUHANI SINGH**

The king has fallen. For the first time in at least four years, Virat Kohli lost the crown of India's No. 1 sportsperson in INDIA TODAY's Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll. The former cricket captain was beaten by retired former skipper M.S. Dhoni, who as of now only plays in the Indian Premier League (IPL).

Cricketers have usually dominated the MOTN poll, but even in this non-Olympics year, javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra was fresh in the minds of Indians. He recently added two silvers—in the Diamond League and the World Athletics Championship—to his collection. The captain of the hockey team, Manpreet Singh, featured in the top five, as did his female counterpart, Rani Rampal. Meanwhile, shuttler P.V. Sindhu has become the indisputable No. 1 pick for female sportsperson. The recent Commonwealth Games (CWG) gold medal only adds to her legend, with her erstwhile coach Pullela Gopichand recently hailing her as one of India's greatest female athletes. MOTN respondents also recognised another legend, Mithali Raj, whose performances put women's cricket on the map and who recently retired after a storied career of over two decades. Weightlifter Mirabai Chanu, who won India its first gold at the CWG, and Smriti Mandhana, vice-captain of the women's cricket team that won silver, also held on to their positions. ■



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Q. Who do you think is India's No. 1 sportsperson (male)?



2 VIRAT KOHLI **24%** [27%]



3 NEERAJ CHOPRA **10%** [11%]



4 ROHIT SHARMA **10%** [11%]



5 MANPREET SINGH **4%** [2%]

Q. Who do you think is India's No. 1 sportsperson (female)?



2 MITHALI RAJ **27%** [11%]



3 MIRABAI CHANU **12%** [12%]



4 SMRITI MANDHANA **11%** [3%]



5 RANI RAMPAL **6%** [4%]

Rest others; Aug. 2022 figures in bold; Jan. 2022 figures in brackets; - No data